# 10
# Military Attaché in Algeria

My preparations for the new assignment comprised briefings at the Army HQ, visits to various defence and industrial installations, and language training. The Army HQ insisted that I relearn Arabic, whereas we were told that in Algeria, French was more commonly spoken. We left for Algiers in December 1987. For me and our children, Vivek and Sonia, it was the first time we had left the shores of India. Rohini had lived in Afghanistan and France, where her father had been posted as a defence attaché, and had even travelled all over Europe and UK. Besides, she spoke French fluently and taught me as well. So she was our French teacher, guide and interpreter during the initial period of our stay in Algeria. Later, I joined the Alliance Francaise and took the French language course. Within a few months, I began to speak and write reasonably well; well enough to read *Le Monde*.

Our ambassador, Vijay Nambiar, was an outstanding diplomat. He and his wife, Malini, were very warm towards us and helped me to start the defence wing in our mission in Algiers. My task was to represent the armed forces of our country and build bridges of friendship between the two militaries. It is the second largest country in Africa and one of the most beautiful. It extends from the Mediterranean Sea to the middle of the Sahara desert. I got an opportunity to visit the length and breadth of this country and also some of its defence formations and establishments. Since they had mostly Soviet-origin equipment like T 72 tanks, Mig 21 aircraft and naval ships and submarines, they were keen to collaborate with us, particularly in the repairs, maintenance and overhaul of such equipment. Unfortunately, we could not help them much because of